

Chapter 13: Too Close to Ignore

Jenny didn't expect him to come back the next day.

But he did.

Same time.

Same table.

Same calm expression.

Like nothing had happened.

Like he hadn't said *I missed you* in the middle of a quiet street.

Jenny told herself she wouldn't react.

She failed immediately.

"Same as usual?" she asked, voice flat.

"Yes."

Austin didn't look up right away.

That was new again.

He was... quieter.

Not distant.

Just different.

Jenny placed the order down.

"Tea."

"Yes."

"Anything else?"

"No."

She turned to leave.

But his voice stopped her.

"Jenny."

She sighed.

"What?"

"You look tired."

"I am tired."

"Not from work."

Jenny turned slowly.

"...What does that mean?"

Austin met her eyes.

"Something is bothering you."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You're bothering me."

That earned a faint pause.

Then—

"That's not what I meant."

"Then stop guessing."

"I'm not guessing."

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You always say that."

Austin leaned back slightly.

"You don't sleep properly."

Jenny froze.

That was too accurate.

Too specific.

"How would you know that?" she asked carefully.

Austin hesitated for a fraction of a second.

"I can tell."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the truth."

Jenny shook her head.

"You're impossible."

"And you're avoiding again."

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"I have work."

"You always have work."

"Yes."

A pause.

Then Austin said quietly,

"You're using it as an excuse."

That hit harder than it should have.

Jenny stepped closer.

"Why do you care so much?"

Silence.

Not awkward.

Not tense.

Just... real.

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said,

"I don't know how to stop."

Jenny went still.

The restaurant noise faded behind her.

For a second.

Just a second.

It was only him.

Only her.

Jenny looked away first.

"Don't say things like that."

"Why?"

"Because it makes things complicated."

Austin's gaze sharpened slightly.

"They already are."

Jenny shook her head.

"No. I mean worse."

A pause.

Then softly—

"Worse for who?"

Jenny didn't answer.

Because she didn't know.

The day passed too slowly.

Jenny felt it everywhere.

In his silence.

In his presence.

In the way he didn't leave early like before.

He stayed.

Longer.

Watching less.

But noticing more.

And it was worse somehow.

Because now it felt intentional.

Not curiosity.

Something closer.

Jenny caught herself glancing at him again.

She stopped immediately.

"Focus," she muttered to herself.

Bao leaned over.

"You're doing it again."

"I'm not doing anything."

"You looked at him."

"I look at customers."

"Not like that."

Jenny glared.

"Like what?"

Bao smiled knowingly.

"Like you're waiting for him to look back."

Jenny turned away fast.

Too fast.

Because he had.

Later that afternoon, the restaurant slowed.

Austin stayed seated.

Reading again.

But not fully focused.

Jenny noticed that too.

He kept looking up.

Not often.

But enough.

Like something was on his mind.

Eventually, Jenny walked over.

"You're still here," she said.

"I said I would be."

"You always say that."

"And I always mean it."

That made her pause.

Austin closed the document.

"You've been avoiding me today."

Jenny frowned.

"I haven't."

"You have."

"I've been working."

"You've been passing my table faster."

Jenny stopped.

"...That's not true."

"It is."

A beat.

Then Jenny sighed.

"Fine. Maybe I have."

"Why?"

She hesitated.

That was the problem.

She didn't have a good answer.

So she said the first thing that came out.

"Because you're distracting."

Austin tilted his head slightly.

"That's new."

"It shouldn't be."

A pause.

Then quietly—

“I don’t want to distract you.”

Jenny laughed once.

“You’re not exactly succeeding.”

His expression softened slightly.

Not much.

But enough.

“Then what should I do?” he asked.

Jenny blinked.

“...What?”

“What should I do so I don’t distract you?”

That question shouldn’t have mattered.

But it did.

Jenny looked at him longer than she meant to.

Then said quietly,

“Leave things the way they were.”

Silence.

Austin didn’t respond immediately.

Then—

“I don’t think I can.”

That was worse.

Because it sounded honest.

Too honest.

Jenny stepped back.

"Finish your food."

Austin didn't argue.

He just watched her for a moment longer.

Then said softly,

"You're running again."

Jenny froze slightly.

Then walked away anyway.

Because he was right.

And she didn't know how to stop.

That night, Jenny stood outside the restaurant alone.

The air was cold.

Quiet.

She should have gone home.

But she didn't.

Because she kept thinking about one thing.

I don't think I can.

And for the first time...

Jenny wasn't sure if she was the one being chased anymore.

Or if she was the one slowly staying.